

nancially 'free,' as in free beer! This is especially true of OS electronics, where there is a physical, tangible aspect. You get lots of designs online, as well as free and OS software for everything from design to simulation. But when it comes to actually making the product, you need to buy some components.

While some like to go backpacking to their local electronics bazaar, it is also possible to buy most of what you need online. There are sites like Adafruit Industries (<http://www.adafruit.com/>), Make Magazines' Maker Shed (<http://www.makershed.com/>) and SparkFun Electronics (<https://www.sparkfun.com/>), Simple Labs (www.simplelabs.co.in) and Explore Labs (www.explorelabs.com), which have a thriving online community that answers doubts, shares tutorials, projects and ideas, while also selling electronic components, parts, kits, etc. Or, you can check out retailers like Kits'n'Spares (www.kitsnspares.com), Futurlec (www.futurlec.com),

AliExpress (www.aliexpress.com) or Robotkits (www.robotkits.org).

Most of these sites sell all kinds of electronics, not just OS ones, so look for what you want. Before you buy, compare the pricing and deals on a few websites and then order, because it is possible to get free shipping and other offers.

5. How do I find projects, get doubts cleared?

This is perhaps the easiest question to answer—because that is the main advantage of OS electronics. Nobody wants to keep their knowledge to themselves in the OS community. If they have found a better way of doing something, they want to share it. If they find an enthusiast wanting to learn something, they are eager to teach.

There are umpteen OS electronics websites with thriving forums and communities. OpenElectronics (<http://www.open-electronics.org/>),

OpenCores (<http://opencores.org/>) and OpenCircuits (<http://www.opencircuits.com>) are some of the sites that cover only OS electronics. That apart, most of the do-it-yourself websites like MAKE: (<http://makezine.com/>), Electronics For You (www.electronicforu.com), Instructables (<http://www.instructables.com/>), Popular Mechanics DIY (<http://www.popularmechanics.com/technology/how-to/>) and DIY (<http://diy.org/>) also have lots of OS content and projects.

The websites of OS boards, such as Arduino (<http://arduino.cc/>), Raspberry Pi (<http://www.raspberrypi.org/>) and Beagleboard (<http://beagleboard.org/>), are perfect places to go to if you are working with these specific boards because you find innumerable ideas, solutions to problems, and enthusiastic knowledge-sharing on these communities. ●

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